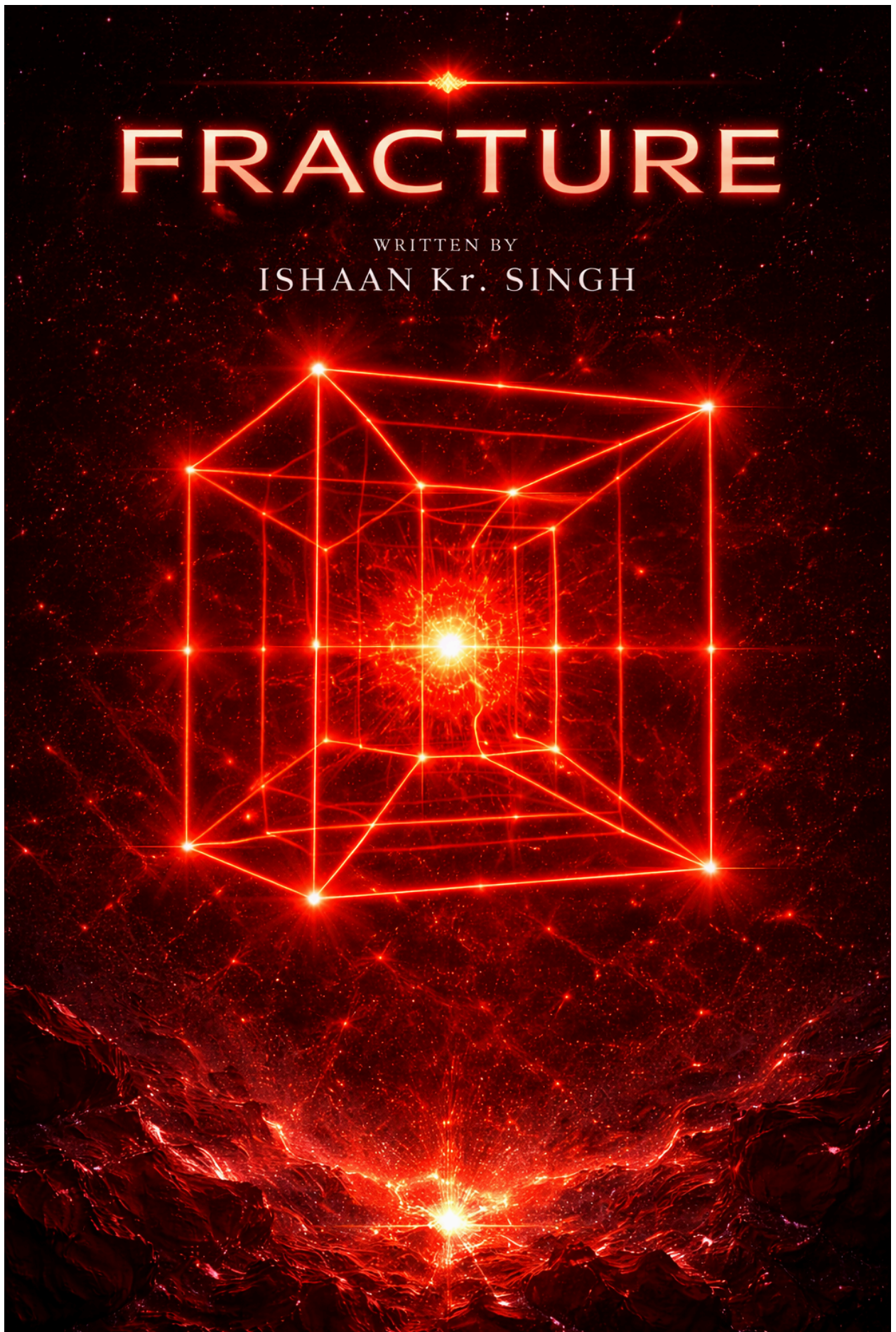


FRACTURE

WRITTEN BY
ISHAAN Kr. SINGH



FRACTURE

Chapter 1: Criminal

NASA ke un chamakte corridors se nikal kar jab Ishaan wapas India aaya, toh logon ko laga wo ek 'Vijayee Laut' hai.

Par Ishaan ke liye ye sirf ek bhaag-daur thi.

INDOVAR ke baad duniya ne use 'Hero' kaha. Waqt rath banae ke baad duniya ne use 'Legend' kaha. Par Ishaan ko ye sab titles ek bojh ki tarah lagta tha — jo kandhe par hota hai par dikhta nahi.

Usne apni company ki neev rakhi — **IKS. Ishaan Kinetic Systems.**

Building vishal thi — glass aur steel se bani, sheher ke beech mein. Bahar se chamakti thi. Andar ka sannata usse bhi bada tha.

Ishaan ab aksar apni lab ki khidki se baahar dekhta rehta. Wo log jo use 'God' kehte the — wo nahi jaante the ki ye 'God' raat ko sota nahi hai. Ki ye 'God' kabhi kabhi bas khidki ke bahar dekhta rehta hai — bina kisi reason ke.

Professor Kenji America ja chuke the — NASA ke naye projects ke liye. Par unki rozana ki video calls Ishaan ke liye ek sahara thi.

"Ishaan, tumne khud ko ek qile mein band kar liya hai," Kenji aksar kehte.

Ishaan sirf muskura deta.

Idhar Avika ne apna CA clear kar liya tha. Safal. Independent. Par uska dil wahi atka tha — us 'Invisible' Ishaan ke paas jo ab poori duniya ko dikhai deta tha par khud ko nahi dekhta tha.

Uske gharwale jab shaadi ke liye ladkon ki tasveerein dikhate — wo unhe dekhti tak nahi.

Wo intezaar kar rahi thi. Kab tak — use khud nahi pata tha.

Aur phir ek dopehar — sab kuch badal gaya.

Aasmaan ka rang achanak badalne laga. Neela rang dheere dheere ek gehre, gande laal mein badal gaya.

Aur phir — dararein padne lagi.

Poori duniya mein achanak ajeeb se **Red Portals** khulne lage. Aasmaan mein kisi khule hue zakhm ki tarah. Kahin angoothi ke size ke — kahin itne vishal ki unki garjan se dharti kaanp uthti thi.

NASA ne report kiya ki Jupiter ka ek chaand ek aise hi portal mein sama gaya — jaise kisi ne use aasmaan se mita diya ho.

Log darr gaye. Sheher mein afra-tafri machi. Koi nahi jaanta tha ki ye kya hai — kahan se aaya hai — kab band hoga.

Par kuch log jaante the.

Ya shayad — unhe blame kiya ja raha tha.

IKS ke inauguration ka din tha.

Building ke bahar hazaron log the. Cameras. Media. Excitement. Ek nayi shuruaat ka jashan.

Ishaan stage par tha. Microphone haath mein. Usne ek baar poori jagah par nazar daali — logo, cameras, log.

Abhi bolna shuru hi kiya tha ki —

Kaali gaadiyaan aayi. NASA ke bade officials. Uniform mein log. Seedha stage par.

"Ishaan Kumar Singh," ek officer ne microphone ke saamne aake kaha — poori media ke saamne — "Aap par aarop hai ki ye saare Red Portals — ye tabaahi — ye sab aapke time travel experiments ka natija hai."

Bheed mein sannata chha gaya.

Phir afra-tafri.

Ishaan ke paas koi jawab nahi tha — abhi ke liye. Use pata tha ki usne physics ke saath chhed-chhaad ki thi. Par kya natija itna bhayankar hoga — ye usne socha bhi nahi tha.

Haathkadiyan aayi.

Wo haathkadiyan Ishaan ke haathon par nahi — uske bharose par lagi thi.

Poori media ke saamne. Poori duniya ke saamne.

AIR 1. Cyber-God.

Aaj — ek criminal.



Chapter 2: Dimensional Nexus

Jail ki thandi aur silan bhari deewaron ke beech Ishaan baitha tha.

Bahar bheed uske khoon ki pyaasi thi — usse 'Universe ka Qatil' keh rahi thi. News channels par experts baith ke bata rahe the ki Red Portals kyun khule — aur har baar jawab mein ek hi naam aata tha.

Ishaan Kumar Singh.

Tabhi wahan Avika pahunchi.

Usne kuch nahi kaha. Bas Ishaan ke haath ko pakda — uska haath barf ki tarah thanda tha. Ek pal ki khamoshi mein itna kuch tha jo words mein nahi aata tha.

"Bhuvan bhai kahan hain?" Ishaan ne bahut dhire se poochha.

"Wo Mikhail ko hospital le gaya hai," Avika ki aankhon mein nami thi. "Mikhail ko achanak chakkar aur ultiyen aane lagi thi. Wo pareshan hai Ishaan."

Jitendar ne apni पूरी sifarish lagayi — aur Ishaan ko bail mil gayi.

Lab pahunchte hi Bhuvan ka phone aaya. Uski awaaz mein aansu the — par wo khushi ke the.

"Ishaan... Mikhail pregnant hai! Main... main baap banne wala hoon!"

Ishaan ki aankhon mein ek pal ke liye chamak aayi. Usne muskurakar badhai di. Par jaise hi usne phone rakha — usne baahar laal aasmaan ko dekha.

Ek nayi zindagi janam lene wali thi. Aur poora universe maut ki kagaar par tha.

Professor Kenji agle hi din India pahunch gaye.

Lab mein andhera tha — sirf monitors ki laal roshni unke chehron par pad rahi thi. Ishaan ne screen par ek complex mathematical model dikhaya.

"Sir, hamara multiverse ab tak ek 4D Sphere ki tarah balance mein tha," Ishaan ne kaha. Uski awaaz mein ek thandak thi. "Par SAHAY ke sensors bata rahe hain ki ab ye ek 4D Cube — yaani Dimensional Nexus — mein badal chuka hai. Ye natural nahi hai. Koi hume is nexus ke beech mein kheench raha hai — jaise koi makkhi ko jaale mein kheencha jaata hai."

Kenji ne screen ko gaur se dekha. "Toh hume kya karna hoga?"

"Nexus ke center mein jaana hoga. Wahan jo bhi hai — use rokna hoga."

Mikhail ki halat aur Kenji ki dhalti umra dekh kar Ishaan ne ek faisla sunaya — "Aap dono yahan rahenge. Hum jaayenge."

Kenji ne virodh kiya — par Ishaan ki aankhon mein wo determination thi jo argument band kar deti hai.

Lab mein din raat kaam shuru hua.

Waqt-Rath purani thi — PARADOX ke safar ke baad uski haalat theek nahi thi. Ishaan ne use portals ke layak update karna shuru kiya. Naya engine. Naya shield system. Ek aisa navigation jo Dimensional Nexus ke chaaron taraf ke portals ko read kar sake.

SAHAY full capacity par tha — data process kar raha tha, routes calculate kar raha tha.

Roz subah Avika aati. Koi coding nahi aati thi use — par wo hoti thi. Coffee laati thi. Kabhi kabhi sirf paas baithti thi. Aur Ishaan ke liye — kabhi kabhi bas koi paas hona hi kaafi hota hai.

Ek raat — jab sab sone chale gaye the — Avika lab mein ruk gayi.

"Ishaan," usne dheere se kaha. "Kya ye zaruri hai? Kya koi aur raasta nahi?"

Ishaan ne laptop se nazar uthaayi. Avika ki aankhon mein darr tha — wo darr nahi jo maut se hota hai, wo darr jo kisi ke jaane se hota hai.

"Koi aur raasta hota toh main wahan hota," Ishaan ne seedha kaha. "Par ye mujhe hi karna hoga."

Avika ne kuch nahi kaha. Bas nod kiya.

Aur us raat dono wahan baithe rahe — laptop ki roshni mein — koi kuch nahi bola. Par dono jaante the ki jo unsaid tha, wo said se zyada bhari tha.

Kuch din baad — Waqt-Rath taiyar thi.

Nahi — ye wahi purani Waqt-Rath nahi thi. Ye kuch aur thi. Better. Stronger. Ek aisa ship jo portals ke andar, space-time ke paar, Dimensional Nexus ke center tak ja sake.

Ishaan ne ek baar use dekha — lab ke center mein khadi, screens ki roshni mein chamakti hui.

Avika uske paas aayi. Dono ne ek doosre ki taraf dekha — wo nazar jo tab hoti hai jab dono jaante hain ki aage kya hai par koi nahi kehna chahta.

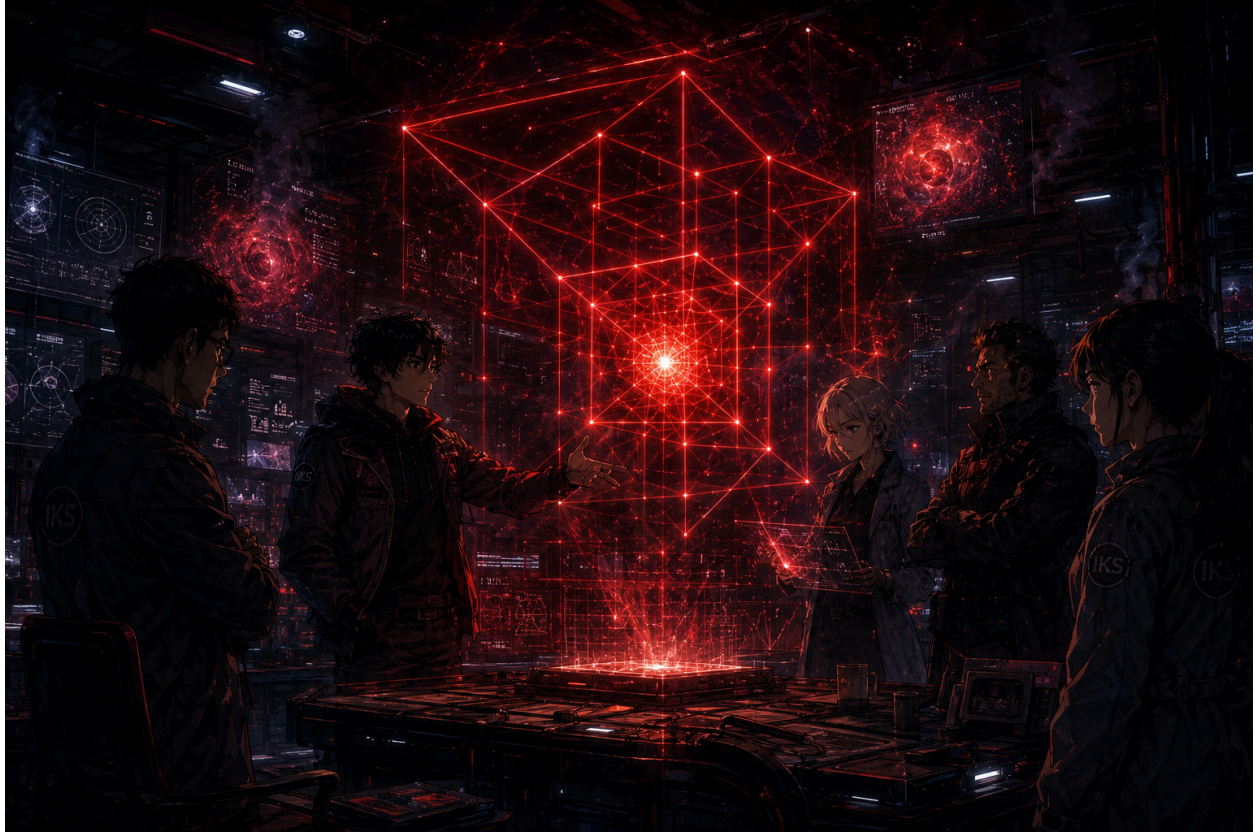
Ishaan ne ship ka darwaza khola.

"SAHAY, sab systems check karo."

"Sab ready hain Ishaan," SAHAY ne kaha. "Dimensional Nexus ka center 4 portals ke paar hai."

Ishaan andar gaya. Avika bhi.

Ship ne jaise hi portal mein entry li — ek bhayanak jhatke ne unhe space-time ke us paar phek diya.



Chapter 3: An Unknown Friend

Jab Ishaan ki aankh khuli toh har taraf mitti aur dhuaan tha.

Ship crash ho chuki thi — ek ajeeb jagah par. Na aasmaan neela tha, na zameen normal. Har taraf ek gehra, bhaari andhera tha — jaise suraj ne kabhi is jagah ka rukh hi nahi kiya tha. Hawa thi — par wo hawa nahi thi jo saans lene layak lagti hai. Thodi bhaari. Thodi ajeeb.

"Avika!" Ishaan chillaya.

"Yahan hoon," ek kaanpti hui awaaz aayi — thodi door se. Avika ek bade patthar ke paas baithi thi — haath se apna sar pakde. Zakhmi nahi thi — par hilayi hui zaroor thi.

Dono ek doosre ke paas aaye.

"SAHAY, kahan hain hum?" Ishaan ne poochha.

"Ek alag universe mein," SAHAY ne kaha. "Dimensional Nexus ke raste mein ek portal galat jagah khula. Ye universe stable nahi hai Ishaan. Yahan darkness dominant hai — har cheez mein, har jagah mein."

Ishaan ne charon taraf dekha. Dhund thi — gehra, kaali. Koi chiriya nahi. Koi hawa nahi. Bas ek bhaari khamoshi jo andar tak mehsoos hoti thi.

"Ship?" Avika ne poochha.

Ishaan ne peeche dekha. Ship ka aadha hissa mitti mein dhansa hua tha — engine se dhuaan nikal raha tha.

"Nahi udegi," Ishaan ne kaha. "Kuch aur dhundhna hoga."

Chalte hue unhone dekha ki ye duniya sirf andheri nahi — khatarnak bhi thi.

Dhund mein se aakritiyan nikalti thi. Kabhi chaar paon wali. Kabhi itni badi ki pura sharir nazar nahi aata tha.

Ek baar ek vishalkay rakshas seedha Avika ki taraf jhapta — tez, bina awaaz.

Ishaan ne Astra Ring ghumayi. "Astra — Talwar!"

Neeli bijli chamki. Rakshas gir gaya.

"Paas raho," Ishaan ne kaha. "Alag mat hona."

Dono saath chalte rahe — andheron mein roshni dhundha. Phir door se ek halki si roshni dikhi.

Roshni ek tooti hui lab se aa rahi thi.

Purani. Deewarein adhi giri hui. Andar kuch screens thi — halki, kaanpti roshni mein.

Ishaan aur Avika andar gaye.

Wahan ek kone mein ek aadmi baitha tha. Akela. Baal bikhre. Kapde purane. Haath mein ek khaali glass. Uski aankhon mein ek aisi thakaan thi jo sirf tab aati hai jab koi bahut zyada akela reh chuka ho.

Usne awaaz suni toh nazar uthaayi.

Ishaan ko dekha — poora dekha. Upar se neeche.

Phir Avika ko.

Phir wapas Ishaan ko.

Uska chehra ek ajeeb confusion mein tha — jaise koi cheez dekhna chahta ho par aankhon par bharosa nahi kar pa raha ho.

Ishaan ne haath uthaya. "Hum koi khatara nahi hain."

Woh aadmi kuch nahi bola. Bas uthke ek kone mein chala gaya — door se Ishaan ko dekta raha. Jaise koi jaanwar pehli baar insaan dekhta hai — na darr, na bharosa. Sirf observation.

"Tu Ishaan hai," usne akhir mein kaha. Dheere se. Jaise baat khud se kar raha ho.

"Haan. Aur tum?"

"Om."

Om ne unhe paas nahi aane diya — pehle ghante mein.

Wo door baitha raha. Kabhi Ishaan ko dekta — phir nazar hata leta. Koi purani memory rok rahi thi use.

Ishaan ne pressure nahi diya. Bas wahan baitha raha. Avika bhi.

SAHAY ne earpiece mein dheere se kaha — "Ye bahut waqt se akele hain Ishaan. Inke patterns se lag raha hai — kaafi zyada waqt se."

Ek ghante baad Om ne poochha — door se hi — "Tum kahan se aaye ho?"

"Doosre universe se," Ishaan ne seedha kaha.

Om ne ek pal socha. Phir bola — "Mere universe mein Ishaan mar gaya tha."

Khamoshi.

"Main wo Ishaan nahi hoon," Ishaan ne dheere se kaha.

Om ne is baar nazar nahi haatayi.

Dheere dheere — bahut dheere — Om paas aaya.

Usne Ishaan ko verify kiya — features, aankhein, Astra Ring.

"Ye ring... mere universe ke Ishaan ke paas bhi thi," Om ne dheere se kaha.

"Haan."

Om floor par baith gaya — seedha saamne. Pehli baar directly.

"Tum yahan kyun aaye ho?"

Ishaan ne bataya — Dimensional Nexus, portals, koi jo sab kuch kar raha hai. Om ne suna — poora suna.

Phir bola — "Mere universe ke Ishaan bhi kuch aisa karne wale the. Pehle SAJ-26 virus aaya. Sab khatam ho gaye. Main akela bacha hoon."

Uski awaaz mein koi dard nahi tha — sirf ek flat, khaali bayan. Itni baar soch chuka tha ki dard bhi nahi hota ab.

Avika ki aankhein bhar aayi. Usne kuch nahi kaha.

Raat bhar koi nahi soya.

Om ne bataya — ye universe kaisa hai. Suraj saalon se nahi nikla. Koi zinda nahi — sirf wo aur kuch survivors aur gehre underground.

Ishaan ne suna. Beech mein nahi toka.

Jab Om khatam hua toh Ishaan ne kaha — "Hume Nexus ke center tak jaana hai. Ship kaam nahi kar rahi. Koi aur raasta chahiye."

Om uthke lab ke ek kone mein gaya. Wahan kuch parts the — purane, dhool mein dabe.

"Ye mere universe ke Ishaan ke the," Om ne kaha. "Maine sambhal ke rakha tha. Mujhe coding nahi aati — par jaata nahi tha."

Ishaan ne parts uthaye. Dekha. Samjha.

"SAHAY, in parts se kya ban sakta hai?"

"Ek portable portal device — Wrist par pehno, button press karo, directly Nexus ke coordinates tak pahuncho. Par Ishaan — ye sirf do logon ke liye hai. Tum aur Avika. Om yahan rahega."

Ishaan ne Om ki taraf dekha.

Om ne samjha. Nod kiya. "Main yahan theek hoon. Adat hai."

Us ek line mein itna kuch tha.

Dono ne milke Waqt-Bandh banaya.

Avika ne parts pakadte hue madad ki. SAHAY ne calculations diye. Ishaan ne logic lagaya. Om ne alien technology ka jo hissa jaanta tha — woh lagaya.

Subah hote hote — do chhote sleek devices taiyar the.

Waqt-Bandh.

Ishaan ne ek kalai par pehna. Avika ne doosra.

Om wahan khada tha — door se. Uske chehre par koi expression nahi tha. Par aankhon mein kuch tha — shayad wo pehli cheez thi jo usne bahut waqt baad feel ki thi.

Umeed.

Ishaan ne Om ki taraf dekha. "Hum wapas aayenge."

Om ne sirf itna kaha — "Mere universe ke Ishaan ne bhi aisa hi kaha tha."

Khamoshi.

Phir Ishaan ne button dabaya



Chapter 4: An Old Enemy

Waqt-Bandh ne kaam kiya.

Ek pal andhera — phir ek anant safed roshni.

Ishaan aur Avika Dimensional Nexus ke bilkul beech mein the. Koi zameen nahi thi — sirf ek infinite safed space tha. Charon taraf multiverse ke alag alag nazare aise tair rahe the jaise kisi ne kaanch ka burtan tod diya ho — tukde, par har tukde mein ek poori duniya.

"SAHAY, koi signal?" Ishaan ne poochha.

"Haan. Nexus ke center mein ek presence hai. Bahut badi. Bahut purani."

Avika ne Ishaan ka haath pakda. "Aage chalte hain."

Woh figure door se hi dikha.

Khada tha — bilkul still — jaise statue ho. Par jaise Ishaan aur Avika kareeb aaye, wo muda.

Aur Ishaan ki saansein atak gayi.

Manvik.

Par ye wo Manvik nahi tha jise Ishaan ne pichli baar dekha tha. Is Manvik ki aankhon mein ek aisi thandak thi jo sirf karoron saal ka akelapan de sakta hai. Uska chehra wahi tha — par har cheez alag thi. Uski skin par wo prototype suit ki nanotech wires abhi bhi thi — par ab wo uske sharir ka hissa ban chuki thi. Uske haath mein ek ajeeb sa Trishul tha — kisi metal se nahi, jam chuki energy se bana.

"Tumhe lagta hai tum special ho, Ishaan?" Manvik ki awaaz pure Nexus mein goonji — hazaar jagah se ek saath.

Ishaan ne Astra Ring activate ki. "Manvik, ye sab band karo. Ye portals, ye tabaahi—"

"Band?" Manvik hans diya — aur us hassi mein koi khushi nahi thi. "Maine rukne ke bajaye har multiverse ke us kamzor Ishaan ko dhoondha. Use maara. Uski intelligence chheen li. Aaj mere andar laakhon 'Ishaans' ka dimaag hai." Usne apna Trishul uthaya.

Manvik ne pehla vaar kiya.

Trishul se ek energy wave nikli — itni tez ki Nexus ki safed roshni ek pal ke liye kaali ho gayi. Ishaan ne Astra Ring se shield banaya — par wave itni powerful thi ki wo peeche dhakela gaya. Pair zameen par — jo thi hi nahi — se fisal gaye. Wo girate girate sambhala.

"Astra — Gada Mode!"

Ek purple Gada uske haath mein ban gayi. Ishaan ne swing kiya — tez, powerful.

Manvik ne sirf ek haath uthaya. Gada ruk gayi — hawa mein — jaise kisi ne time freeze kar diya ho.

"Itna hi hai tere paas?" Manvik ne kaha.

Usne apni ungli hilaayi. Gada Ishaan ki taraf hi palat gayi — aur Ishaan seedha peeche ja gira.

Dard tha — poore body mein.

"Astra — Talwar!" Ishaan ne uthke dobara koshish ki.

Talwar bani. Ishaan aage badha — tez, determined. Usne ek ke baad ek vaar kiye — har vaar mein poori taqat. Manvik peeche hata — ek baar, do baar.

Par phir Manvik ne apna Trishul sidha zameen — jo thi hi nahi — par rakha. Aur ek aisi vibration aayi ki Ishaan ke haath se Talwar chhutte chhutte bachi.

Manvik ne Trishul uthaya aur seedha Ishaan ki taraf chala — slow, confident. Jaise jaldi nahi thi. Jaise result pata tha.

"Tu thak chuka hai Ishaan. Main hazaron saal se hun. Tu kuch ghante ka hai."

Ishaan ne daant peese. "Astra — Dhanush!"

Energy ka dhanush bana. Ishaan ne ek ke baad ek arrows chhode — tez, continuous. Manvik ke around energy sparks fly ki. Manvik ruka — ek pal ke liye.

Par sirf ek pal.

Manvik ne apna haath uthaya — aur ek invisible force ne Ishaan ko hawa mein uthaya. Seedha upar. Phir — BANG — neeche patak diya.

Ishaan wahan pada raha. Haanpta hua. Uthne ki koshish ki — par pair ne saath nahi diya. Ek baar. Do baar.

Teesri baar utha — dard ke bawajood.

"Astra — Parshu!" Uske haath mein ek energy axe bani. Ishaan ne ek bhaari swing kiya — seedha Manvik ke Trishul par.

Dono weapons takraye.

Ek bhayanak awaaz. Energy sparks charon taraf. Nexus ki safed roshni ek pal ke liye purple ho gayi.

Aur phir —

Astra Ring — Ishaan ki kalai par — ek tez awaaz ke saath toot gayi.

Tukde. Haath mein sirf ek khaali ring thi — koi energy nahi, koi weapon nahi.

Ishaan ne haath dekha.

Manvik ne dekha.

Aur muskuraya.

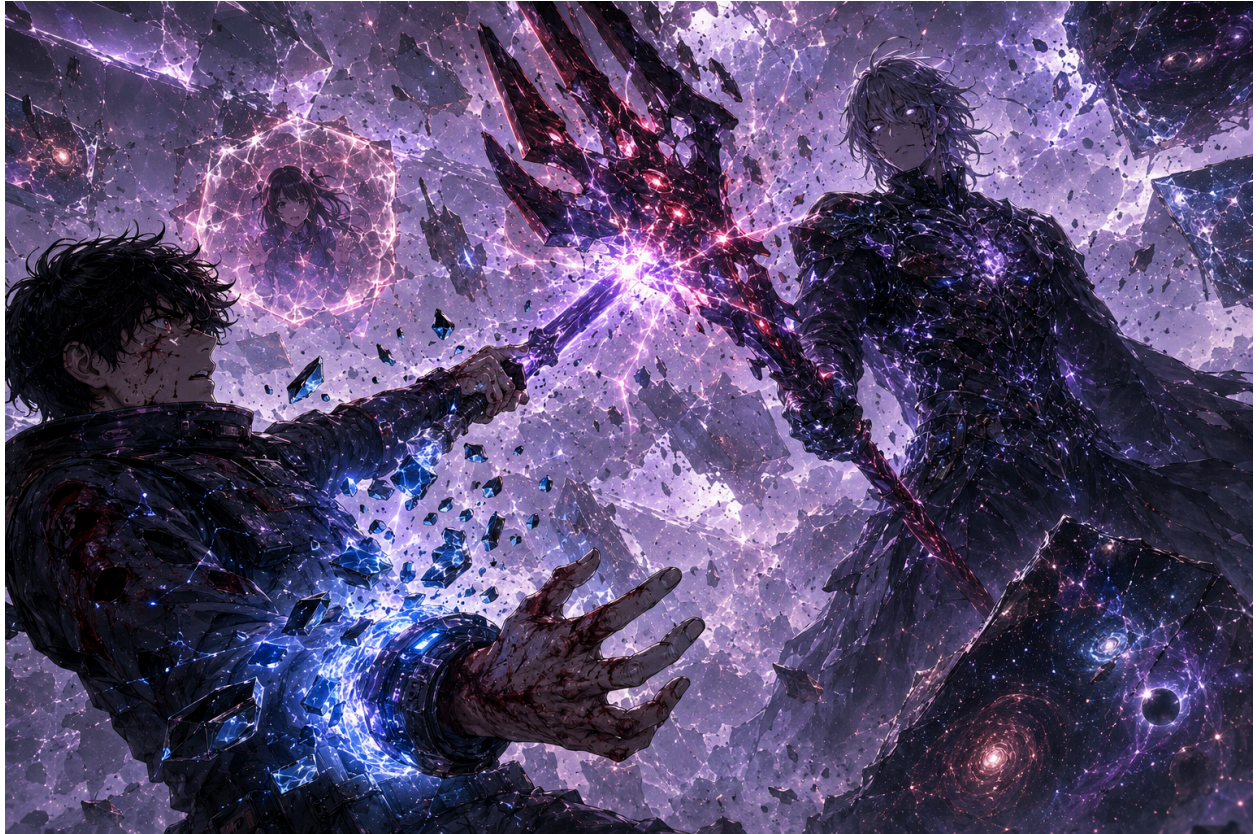
"Ab?" Manvik ne dheere se poochha.

Ishaan wahan khada tha — ring ke tukde haath mein — thaka hua, zakhmi, akela.

Avika door thi — Manvik ki energy field ne use ek jagah rok rakha tha.

"SAHAY..." Ishaan ne dheere se kaha.

SAHAY kuch nahi bola. Pehli baar.



Chapter 5: Fracture

Manvik ne apna Trishul uthaya.

Aur ek aisi energy field bani — purple, bhaari, closing in — jo Ishaan aur Avika dono ko gherne lagi.

"Tum dono mere kisi kaam ke nahi," Manvik ne kaha. "Par main tumhe marunga nahi. Main tumhe wahan bhejoonga jahan se tum kabhi nahi aa paoge."

Ishaan ne field ko rokne ki koshish ki — haath aage badhaye — par Astra Ring toot chuki thi. Koi energy nahi. Koi weapon nahi.

Field tez hoti gayi.

"SAHAY — kuch karo!" Ishaan chillaya.

"Ishaan — main kuch nahi kar sakta. Ye pure Nexus ki energy hai—"

Aur phir — ek jhatka.

Dono ka connection toot gaya. Alag alag portals mein.

War Universe.

Jab dono ki aankh khuli toh kaanon mein dhamako ki awaaz thi.

Aasmaan kaala tha. Zameen par sirf baarood aur lohe ke dher. Sadiyon se yudh chal raha tha is jagah.

Ishaan ne turant Avika ko dekha — safe thi. Abhi tak.

"Wagt-Bandh activate karo," Ishaan ne kaha. "Abhi yahan se nikalte hain."

Avika ne apne wrist device par haath rakha — par darr aur paseene ki wajah se haath thirak gaya.

Device uski kalai se phisal kar door malbe mein ja gira.

Dono ne ek saath dekha — device kahan gira tha.

Aur ek building — jo pehle se adhi tooti thi — jhukne lagi. Dheere. Phir tez.

"Ishaan! Mera device—!" Avika ki awaaz mein wo darr tha jo Ishaan ne aaj se pehle kabhi nahi suna tha. Wo darr nahi jo maut se hota hai — wo darr jo tab hota hai jab koi apni galti ki wajah se doosre ko khatre mein daal deta hai.

Ishaan jhapatne wala tha — seedha Avika ki taraf — par malbe ki pehli layer unke beech mein aa gayi.

"AVIKAAA!"

"ISHAANNN!"

Aur phir — ton bhar concrete. Lohe ki salaakhein. Dhool ka toofan.

Dhool chhayi rahi.

Ishaan wahan khada tha. Hila nahi. Bol nahi raha tha.

"Avika," usne dheere se kaha. Jaise agar dheere bola toh reality badal jaayegi.

Koi jawab nahi.

"Avika." Dobara. Thodi aur tez.

Phir bhi kuch nahi.

Ishaan malbe ki taraf bhaga — haath se patthar hatane lage. Bade bhaari patthar. Ek. Doosra. Teesra. Uske nakhun toot gaye — par wo ruka nahi. Haath laal ho gaye — par wo ruka nahi.

Ruk nahi sakta tha.

Kyunki ruk jaana matlab maan lena hota. Aur wo maan nahi sakta tha.

Jab dhool thodi hati —

Malbe ke neeche se ek haath dikha.

Woh thanda pad chuka tha.

Ishaan ne us haath ko dekha — ek lambi, khaali si nazar se. Jaise dimaag ne process karna band kar diya ho. Jaise time ruk gaya ho.

Us haath mein wahi bracelet tha — jo Ishaan ne banaya tha space-time ke us junction par. Jisme Nebula ki roshni thi, Cristosapiens ki chamak thi. Jo kabhi itna chamakta tha.

Ab wo khoon se laal tha.

Ishaan ne dheere se jhuk ke us thande haath ko apne dono haathon mein liya. Ek pal sirf pakde raha — jaise agar zyada zor se pakda toh warmth wapas aa jaayegi. Jaise agar pakde raha toh wo kaheen nahi jaayegi.

Phir usne us haath ko apne chehre se lagaya.

Aur wahan baith gaya. Zameen par. Malbe ke beech. Dhuaan tha, missile ki awaazein thi, sheher jal raha tha — par Ishaan ko kuch nahi dikh raha tha. Kuch nahi sun raha tha.

Andar kuch tha jo toot gaya tha — par us tootne ki koi awaaz nahi thi. Koi cheekh nahi. Koi aansu nahi. Sirf ek aisa khaali pan tha — itna gehra, itna vishaal — ki uski koi tah nahi thi.

Jaise koi puri duniya andar se nikal gayi ho — aur ab wahan sirf ek sunsaan jagah thi.

Kaafi der wahan baitha raha.

Waqt-Bandh abhi bhi uski kalai par tha — Ishaan ka wala. Usne use dekha. Ek baar. Do baar.

Phir button dabaya.

Lab ka portal achanak neeli roshni ke saath khula.

Bhuvan, Mikhail aur Kenji umeed se uski taraf daude — teen chehere jisme anticipation thi, relief thi, sawaal the.

Par jab unhone Ishaan ko dekha — unke qadam wahi ruk gaye.

Ishaan thaka haara tha. Kapde phate hue. Poore sharir par mitti aur sookha hua khoon. Aankhein — jo hamesha kuch sochti rehti thi, hamesha aage ki taraf dekhti thi — aaj bilkul khali thi. Jaise koi ghar ho jisme darwaza khula ho par andar koi na ho.

Uske haath mein sirf ek cheez thi.

Avika ka bracelet.

Wahi bracelet. Khoon se laal. Thanda.

"Ishaan..." Bhuvan ne kaanpti awaaz mein poochha. Poora sawaal nahi poocha — bas ek naam. Par us ek naam mein poora sawaal tha.

"Avika kahan hai?"

Ishaan ne koi jawab nahi diya.

Usne Bhuvan ki taraf dekha — ek pal — phir nazar hata li. Wo khamoshi se un sabke beech se nikal gaya — jaise wo wahan tha hi nahi. Jaise wo pehle se kahin aur tha.

Uske chalne ki awaaz mein wo pehle wala confidence nahi tha. Wo taal nahi thi jisme manzil hoti hai. Sirf ek bhaar tha — kadam darte the par chal rahe the — kyunki ruk jaane ki bhi taqat nahi bachi thi.

Wo apne room mein gaya.

Darwaza andar se band hua.

Poori lab mein sannata chha gaya.

Screens chal rahi thi — data, readings, signals. Sab normal tha bahar se. Sab bilkul abnormal tha andar se.

Kuch der baad — darwaze ke peeche se ek awaaz aayi.

Siskiyan.

Wo koi aam rona nahi tha. Wo wo rona tha jo tab aata hai jab insaan ke paas koi aur raasta nahi hota — jab dard itna bada ho jaata hai ki bahar nahi nikal sakta, andar nahi sama sakta — sirf todta rehta hai. Baar baar. Bina rukke.

Mikhail ne Bhuvan ka haath pakda. Bhuvan ki aankhein bhar aayi — wo aankhein jo ISRO ki mushkilon mein nahi bhari thi, jo space mein nahi bhari thi — aaj bhar aayi.

Kenji ne lab ki khidki se bahar dekha. Bahar raat thi — shant, andhari. Bilkul us dard ki tarah jo koi nahi dekh sakta — par jo tha. Poori tarah tha.

Teen log. Teen alag jagah. Par ek hi cheez feel kar rahe the.

Kuch khatam ho gaya tha.

Kuch aisa jo wapas nahi aayega.

Portals shayad band ho jaayenge. Manvik shayad haar jaayega. Duniya shayad bach jaayegi.

Par Ishaan ke andar jo 'fracture' hua tha —

Wo kabhi nahi bharega.



